

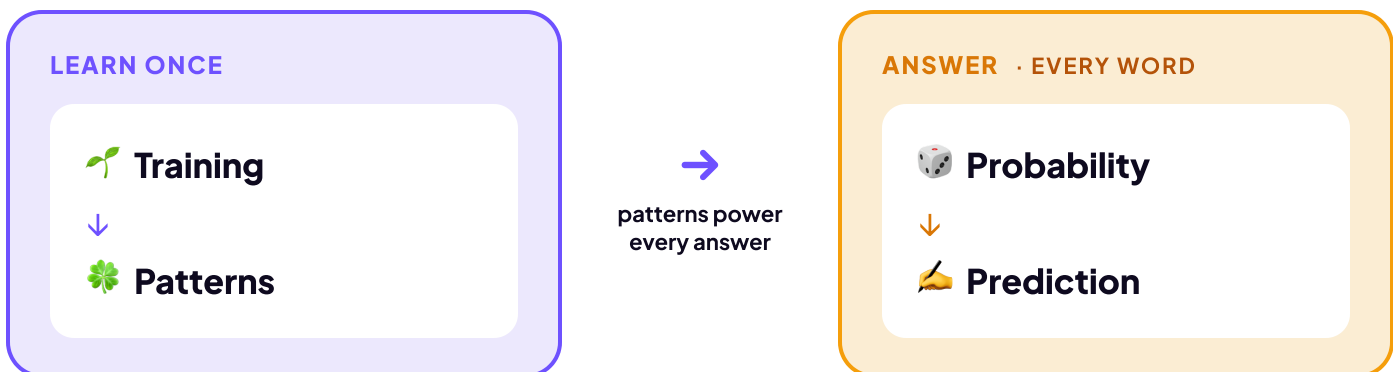
What AI Does Best

AI will take on almost anything you ask: writing, planning, summarizing, coding, drawing, researching, and more. But “can try” is not the same as “built for,” and AI is far better at some kinds of work than others.

We saw this firsthand building this course. AI coded every page and every interaction you’ll see, and we give it a grade of **A+**. It also wrote the first drafts of all lessons, but only earned a **C-**. It made points in the wrong order, added explanations that missed what we meant, and had no real feel for how a lesson should flow.

This gets at the core idea of the lesson. Writing software code is all about patterns, and AI is a pattern-making machine, so it aces that job. But writing strong lessons doesn’t follow a set pattern, so AI can help, but it can’t do the whole thing.

What AI does best grows out of the mechanisms you already learned: it was trained to predict and generate from learned patterns.



Aim that one ability at real work and it shows up as four recognizable shapes: four kinds of job AI is built for.

AI is strongest when the job has one of four shapes.



Patterned transformation

Same meaning, new shape.

AI is strong when you give it input and ask it to turn that input into a clearer, cleaner, or differently structured version. Code has patterns. So do outlines, messy notes, spreadsheets, emails, translations, and documents with repeated fields. When the target shape is clear, AI can transform the material fast.

GOOD FOR

- Coding help
- Reformatting messy data
- Pulling fields out of documents
- Translation
- Turning an outline into prose
- Rewriting for a different audience



Generative variation

Ten versions in ten seconds.

AI builds answers one small piece at a time, choosing from many likely options. That makes it especially useful when you don’t need one perfect answer right away. You need options. It can give you ten angles, five titles, three tones, or a first draft you can react to.

GOOD FOR

- Brainstorming angles
- “Give me 10 variations”
- Rewriting in a different tone
- Alternative phrasings
- Creative options
- First drafts of common documents



Semantic compression and retrieval

Finds the signal in long stuff.

AI is strong at condensing long material into the important parts and helping you find what matters. It can summarize, extract key points, compare passages, and answer questions from documents you provide. Many document tools do this by splitting long text into chunks and searching for the chunks most related to your question.

GOOD FOR

- Summarizing
- Extracting key points
- Finding the relevant section in a long document
- Comparing documents
- Answering questions from supplied material



Structured reasoning and synthesis

Works through the pieces you give it.

AI is also strong at taking facts, constraints, examples, and goals, then helping you work through them. It can compare tradeoffs, debug a problem, critique a draft against a rubric, explain steps, build a plan, or pressure-test an idea. This does not mean it is always right. It means it is useful when you give it the context and still check the result.

GOOD FOR

- Planning
- Debugging
- Comparing options
- Explaining steps
- Critiquing a draft
- Pressure-testing an idea



Why this works: vast exposure

Training gave AI exposure to more examples than any human could read in a lifetime: code, essays, explanations, emails, arguments, stories, documents, and conversations. That’s why it’s fluent with common formats. It has seen many versions of “this kind of thing” before.

But exposure has a limit. AI is often good at the common version of a task, not necessarily the true, current, personal, safest, or best version. That’s why your judgment still matters.



Four strengths. A thousand uses. Most useful AI tasks fit one or more of these shapes: transform a pattern, generate options, compress meaning, or reason through supplied context. The skill isn’t memorizing a hundred clever prompts. It’s spotting which strength the job needs, knowing when none of them fit, and checking the result before you trust it.